is no B-movie sand mafia don. His fortunes, then estimated at Rs 300 crore, had by 2014 already taken his MRS Group to a feature in *Fortune*, which told the story of his rise from a chef at Rambagh Palace and the Governor's House in Jaipur, to a pioneering restaurateur in Jaisalmer as it began to boom in the 1980s, to a big name with interests in liquor, marble, infrastructure, hospitality—and mining. Over the decades, he cultivated excellent relations on both sides of Rajasthan's political binary, and has consequently carried on his business unmolested. Indeed, for long, he had prominent BJP leaders as his partners. But it was in 2020 that he edged closer to prime-time news, though still backstage. It was at his Hotel Suryagarh in Jaisalmer that then Congress CM Ashok Gehlot lassoed in over a hundred loyalist ministers and MLAs when Sachin Pilot, then his deputy and PCC chief, revolted.

The one intriguing thing about the raid was caste: Meghraj is a prominent Rajput face, big enough for irate community members to get the hashtags #RajputsAgainstBJP and #StandWithMeghraj among the top trends on X by February 15. Associated with many community-centred outfits, he is often adoringly designated as a 'Bhamashah', after Rana Pratap's legendary minister and patron, implying a rich and magnanimous friend of the community.

So why would the BJP risk incurring the wrath of one of its core support groups? The answer may lie in a combination of factors. One theory discarded soon enough was that it was an attempt to keep Jat leader and Khinwsar MLA Hanuman Beniwal in good humour: he had staged protests against Meghraj's business last June, and now sprang to take credit for goading Sharma into action. More likely, Meghraj may have fallen irredeemably afoul of other powerful figures within the ruling establishment, and the raids were the culmination of a rift with an emerging Rajput cartel. In this reading, it's an intra-caste affair, and Rajput loyalties towards the BJP are anyway deemed so solid as to not cause much concern. And the old mafia-political nexus was proving to be the biggest obstacle in the way of fulfilling the revised policy.

Talking to INDIA TODAY on February 29, Meghraj made that rivalry angle explicit, saying, "The ED raids at our establishments and the mining department's raids on our sand mines and stocks are part of an ongoing battle of dominance over sand mining, with the son of a top BJP leader backing a rival group and the government pushing for sand from desiltation of dams." The Sharma regime presents it as a cleansing operation on a long history of rampant illegal mining and its attendant violence, to which the scarred beds of non-perennial rivers and the banks of picturesque dam reservoirs stand testimony.



MAJOR MINER Meghraj Singh Shekhawat

MEGHRAJ IS NO B-MOVIE SAND MAFIA DON. HIS FORTUNES, THEN ESTIMATED AT Rs 300 CRORE, HAD BY 2014 TAKEN HIS MRS GROUP TO A FEATURE IN *FORTUNE*

Sand mining is a vexed issue where a total ban by the Supreme Court in 2017 had only triggered more illegality and a spurt in prices, till a qualified return to the old leases was allowed in 2021. But none of the court's mandated safeguards were kept in sight as the mining apparatus went back to its voracious ways. Now, the state is pushing for an innovative way to solve all problems in one go: save the rivers yet get sand, while keeping a check on the old mafia. In a nutshell, it entails dredging up sedimented river silt and extracting its sand content. This will feed the enormous market for sand in the construction industry, while restoring the capacity of dams and giving rivers with heavily damaged beds a breather and a chance for replenishment. An emerging entrepreneur, Nilesh Gadhiya, who came from Gujarat two decades ago, has been entrusted with the project for three dams, which also promises to rewrite the ongoing battle over mining contracts and the corresponding power it yields.

There's a touch of continuity here: the three-dam contract was awarded during the Congress regime and the Sharma dispensation has opted to back it. Shikhar Agrawal, who was key to envisaging the policy turn as additional chief secretary (ACS), irrigation, is now the ACS to the CM. Experts say the project, the first of its scale in India, can be the model for many big dams (such as Punjab's Bhakra) where desiltation has been held up due to costs. The three dams where the experiment will run are Bisalpur in Tonk, Som Kamla Amba in Dungarpur and Gudda in Bundi. If they show the way to the future, that would be a happy outcome to a muddy story. ■